

THE IMPERIUM



Never forget that the Vilani are Human.

We aren't up against out-and-out E.T.s, with wavy tentacles and retractable eyes. The Vilani may not be exactly like us, but at bottom they have

the same wants and needs. Their culture is unusual by our standards, but our ancestors from Cortez to MacArthur all managed to deal with divergent cultures.

None of this is new. We've been here before, and we've won before.

*– Lt. Colonel Jing Xue,
opening lecture on Vilani Psychology,
Copernicus Naval College (3008)*

IMPERIAL SOCIETY

The initial thing that any Terran notices about Imperial society is its stable, monolithic nature. Like many first impressions, this one is only a partial truth. The Vilani have developed a culture that spans thousands of star systems, and they specifically discourage other folkways, but it's still Human nature to differentiate if given half a chance. As remarkable as the *Ziru Sirka* may be for its homogeneity, it only got that way, and only stays that way, thanks to numerous processes that actively work to keep it so.

VILANI PSYCHOLOGY

The Imperium is built on four primary psychological principles, which are drilled into Vilani from birth. All four are designed to maintain the

status quo, and to keep Vilani society vibrant.

Conservatism

Not long after Terrans encountered the Vilani, one wit observed that “they make the ancient Egyptians look like wild-eyed revolutionaries.” The Vilani made their last major technological innovation at about the time Terrans were figuring out how to smelt iron.

This is not due to a flaw in Vilani psychology. The Vilani once had a technologically advancing society much like that of Terra. They are not incapable of learning new things, or even of inventing them. They simply choose not to.

Terrans sometimes compare Vilani conservatism to that of ancient Egypt or the Inca. This misses a critical fact: Imperial society was developed by a

rational, scientific people with a worthy goal in mind – to transform society into a tool for giving people a place, and making them *happy* with that place. A more exact Terran analogy might be to pre-industrial China, where Confucian ideology was developed along similar lines and for similar purposes.

To the Imperial viewpoint, change brings dislocation and unhappiness. It can also create new wealth and opportunities, but once one reaches a certain reasonable quality of life, is continuing forward worth the cost? More than 3,000 years ago, some Vilani came to the conclusion that it wasn't, and over time they convinced everyone else. Vilani conservatism is a conscious choice, designed to maximize happiness in Imperial society, and it was deliberately imposed a long time ago.

The average Vilani citizen may not be aware of the history of this change, but he believes whole-heartedly that his happiness – and that of others – depends on life carrying on in its unchanging way. So long as temptation can be avoided, most Vilani will stick to traditional ways even if it means minor inconvenience. Every day of their lives, they are reminded that what might be convenient or expedient could also be the start of a slippery slope to social breakdown.

Of course, in many cases the Vilani citizen doesn't have to choose inconvenience by following tradition. For example, a common Terran joke claims that there's an easy way to tell a Vilani: he's the one standing at an intersection at two in the morning, rain pouring down on him and not a car in sight, waiting for the light to change so he can cross the street. As with many jokes, there's some truth to this one. The average Vilani citizen, finding himself in such a situation, never dreams of jaywalking – although he might at least think about the idea long enough to reject it. What really prevents this humorous situation from happening is that the Vilani have already considered it. Their crosswalks go *under* the road, and have for millennia, so no pedestrian is ever forced to wait in the rain.

That's typical of the Vilani way. In every field of endeavor, *someone already thought it through thousands of years ago*. The Vilani believe that their ancestors came up with a solution to most problems, and in many cases they're right. Theirs is not a blind conservatism, but one that makes sense, given the work their ancestors did to ensure that the traditions would be worthy of respect.

Collectivism

Terrans sometimes compare Imperial society to the Communist nation-states of 20th-century Terra. This comparison is understandable, especially given the command-driven nature of the Imperial economy, but there are several major points of difference.

The most important difference is that the Vilani do *not* believe in the historical inevitability of their system. They see the *Ziru Sirka* as an achievement, the product of their race's proudest moment. They believe that it needs constant maintenance, or else things will eventually fall back into the bad, chaotic old ways.

Another difference is that the Vilani are not "utopians" – they don't assume that Human nature will change to match the requirements of

their ideal civilization. Instead, they assume that people will still be people, primarily interested in their own personal welfare. Imperial society makes room for those selfish impulses, and deals with them by channeling them, not by hoping that they will cease to exist.

Within these boundaries, the Vilani have come up with their own peculiar form of collectivism. Under the Imperial system, there is a basic standard of living to which everyone is entitled; while not lavish, it is more than adequate to support life. As in Terran society, there are rewards for hard work and success. But these rewards are usually not monetary, but directly material. Housing is handed out by one's employer, as are food, clothing, entertainment devices, and other "perks." The higher one is on the social ladder, the better one's standard of living.

Of course, this concession to Human acquisitiveness has been placed within boundaries that keep it from getting out of hand. For example, the only way to get better perks or a higher standard of living is through promotion. In other words, there is no impersonal way of acquiring them – one's superiors decide when they are deserved. In Terran society, no matter how you get the money, you can buy the goods. In the Imperium, if you've produced like no one else, but at the expense of others, you're more likely to be *demoted* than promoted.

This is not to say that Imperial society has no money; it's just that money exists entirely for accounting purposes. It's associated with a person as one of several metrics used to evaluate him, but he has no control over it. Money in Vilani space has long since evolved to become a virtual representation of production, with no other social or legal role.

Another check on Vilani greed is a kind of "potlatch" custom. When a Vilani citizen is promoted to higher professional or social status, he is expected to be generous with gifts to his colleagues, subordinates, neighbors, and family members. It's considered a point of honor to give more back to the community than one takes from it. Following this tradition gives the successful citizen prestige, and also engenders good relations within the social circle.

Advertising

The Vilani have been exposed to no advertising since the founding of the *Ziru Sirka* and the creation of its command economy. There are very few competing products, and items mostly differentiate themselves according to status. For example, there are different types of shoes, but who has the right to draw each type from the store varies according to class. Since product and consumer are already matched, there is simply no point to taking up time or space in the media to tout a product; at most, a factual report will be broadcast on the news channels to inform citizens that a new item is available.

When Terrans first burst on the scene, they brought their competing products and the concept of advertising with them. At first, many Vilani believed the loud, colorful, 30-second "news programs" that promised amazing things. The common Vilani soon learned the truth of the matter and rapidly swung to the opposite view; many decided to mistrust *anything* a Terran merchant said.

Since then, Terran trade concerns have adapted their advertising to Vilani viewpoints, and won back some of the customers they alienated during the first burst of commerce. A few unscrupulous merchants still try to take advantage of Vilani gullibility, but Terran companies and government try to police this for their own future benefit.

Efficiency

In Vilani society, “perks” are assigned according to personal and group production. Greater production means more perks: more and better personal goods, more luxuries, more status. However, in their quest for increased production, Vilani citizens are constrained in two notable ways.

In places where business can move forward only on a zero-sum basis, for example by putting a competitor out of business, a Vilani has no room to maneuver. It’s unacceptable to ruin someone else for your own benefit. (Naturally, there are some who do not follow this principle, especially the most powerful nobles, who are usually quite willing to destroy their rivals to get ahead.)

Technological innovation is also extremely slow, so increases in productivity aren’t likely in that arena either.

Within these constraints, the best way to prove one’s worth is with *efficiency*. One of the few areas in which the Imperium does permit innovation is in business processes – the question of how one gets work done. A successful innovator in this area can earn rapid promotion and lifelong respect. There is, therefore, an incentive to think of *better ways to work*.

Of course, the Vilani are extremely conservative when it comes to changing how they do things. Their industrial civilization is more than 8,000 years old, and most processes have undergone generations of refinement. A bright manager is up against the collective brainpower of millions, if not billions, of his ancestors when trying to improve the way things are done.

If a Terran dreams up a potentially more efficient way of organizing the factory floor, he will likely think to himself, “Let’s give it a try and see how it works.” A Vilani will assume that someone has already shown that it is not as good as the way things are done now. If his idea appears promising, he assumes it’s because he hasn’t seen the hidden flaws yet. He will spend a great deal of time in the historical archives researching the idea; he will only proceed if he can’t find a previous example. Even then, it is assumed that the way to proceed is to bring it up with his superiors *and* his employees, and

The Vilani Hero

Vilani stories are Human stories, with protagonists and villains, action, mysteries, and all the usual things Humans find interesting. However, certain classes of hero typical of Terran mythology never appear in its Vilani counterpart. There are no “lone wolves,” and no people who seek personal revenge after being failed by society. Vilani heroes are also not quixotic; there’s always a point to their actions. George Leigh Mallory’s excuse for adventure (“Because it’s there!”) is incomprehensible. The Vilani hero works within the system. For example, while many Vilani dramas hinge on crimes, they are always recognizable “police procedurals,” with an emphasis on “procedure.” Holovids that get into the nitty-gritty details of investigation and the hunting down of a perpetrator are endlessly popular. So is a more unusual kind of story that follows the criminal as the system brings him to justice.

“Disaster movies” are also popular. The Vilani are perfectly aware that the universe itself is not under their control, and they get a visceral thrill out of seeing their heroes fight back against what an unfeeling galaxy can hurl against them. Again, the emphasis is on how the Vilani way of life can help people through difficult times. If a hero has to deal with the consequences of, say, an asteroid strike, there is always a contrast between how desperate things are when he is by himself, and how things start to look up when society begins to piece itself together again. Unlike the conventions of Terran “post-apocalyptic” stories, other Humans are never *villains* in Vilani disaster fiction. Instead, the hero provides the seed of inspiration around which fearful or misguided Vilani can gather to rebuild a proper society.

One common Vilani hero is the protagonist who goes “from rags to riches,” in the style of a Horatio Alger story. Vilani society promotes the notion that anyone can go far, if he works within the system and shows talents that the *Ziru Sirka* needs. Such social mobility is less common than it was long ago, but the ideal still holds strong, and the common Vilani citizen loves this kind of story. A weirder version of this genre is about the hero who starts humbly and *stays* poor, but who sets things up so that his descendants can gain wealth. In a way, this tale is an anodyne for the vast majority who never get to riches themselves; it assures them that their efforts are going to pay off down the line even if there’s no sign of it now.

gain consensus from both. If consensus can’t be reached, the innovator might publicize his idea until some other factory can be found willing to give it a try.

In theory, this means that Vilani industry is extremely efficient. However, the organizational resistance to change caused by the need to reach consensus means that radical ideas rarely find a test bed. Most changes are merely incremental tweaks to a pre-existing process. Even those are hard to implement, and many potential innovators are content to let things lie.

Note that Terran technological superiority in some fields is a two-edged sword because of this Vilani

emphasis on efficiency. If Terrans have a genuinely better way of doing something – for example, in computer technology or medicine – the Vilani are nearly helpless to counter it. The necessary dip in production caused by new capital investment is not supportable, unless the investment is going towards the “tried and true.”

On the other hand, when the Vilani do come to understand a Terran process or technology well enough to have confidence in its implementation, the rewards are great. Some forward-looking Vilani rapidly moves up the chain of command due to his success, and Terra loses a bit more of its advantage in flexibility.

Chauvinism

As with most peoples, the Vilani believe that their civilization is the best of all possible societies. In their particular case, they have some grounds for making that judgment. Most Human cultures are as they are by historical accident. In contrast, the *Ziru Sirka* was designed quite deliberately to reflect Vilani values. Where the Vilani's legitimate pride oversteps its bounds is in its exclusivity – the need to judge other cultures as inferior.

Vilani cultural exclusivity derives from the ancient era of the Consolidation Wars, when the proto-Imperium brought every known star-faring society under its own control. In fact, the Consolidation Wars were fought in order to ensure the stability of Imperial civilization. The wars were a solution for an *economic* problem (that of unregulated innovation and competition), not a cultural one.

Human? I don't know. I mean, they look Human enough, but I've seen a bunch of Vilani three-year-olds in class. They pay attention for hours on end. That's not Human.

– Bill Rodriguez, Nusku colonist (3025)

Thus, the imposition of Vilani traditions on non-Vilani was never their primary intention. Indeed, the early Imperial Vilani considered other cultures to have plenty of merit, at least for the non-Vilani who created them. However, in the centuries since the end of the wars, the Vilani have come to see the imposition of their traditions as an active blessing to the subjected peoples. In effect, they have moved from the rational notion that the *Ziru Sirka* is the best social form for Vilani to the irrational belief that it's the best social form for everyone.

Fortunately for Terra, the Vilani no longer have the will they once had to impose their culture on others. If they still exhibited the same sense of focus that their ancestors had, the Confederation would not last long against the might of the Imperium. However, Vilani complacency has left only a few economists aware of the

threat presented to the Imperial way of life by the existence of a powerful star-faring culture – such as that of Terra – that is outside Imperial control.

At present, most of the men and women in charge of Imperial military equipment truly believe that, thanks to their non-Vilani ways, the Terrans can't present a threat. However, the notion that the existence of independent Terra strikes at one of the pillars of society is slowly starting to filter into the proper channels, with potentially explosive results.

THE VILANI WAY OF LIFE

Vilani are much like Terrans in the broad outlines of their lives – they are born, they are educated, they choose a career, they grow old and die, they give way to their descendants. The details, however, are significantly different.

Birth and Childhood

For most of Vilani history, it was safer to give birth than it was in a corresponding period on Terra. Vland's native disease organisms find it difficult to attack Humans, so Vilani women didn't have to worry about many of the postpartum infections and illnesses that attacked their Terran sisters until the 20th century. Similarly, children were much better off, as scourges like measles and scarlet fever simply didn't exist. Some Terran observers have suggested that Vilani collectivism grew out of the fact that they could become emotionally attached to children with less fear of their dying young. In any case, in the modern day a Terran would find the birth process quite familiar: pre-natal care, a trip to the hospital, and then a brief period of time off work for the parents.

Life diverges when the child starts socializing. Even Terrans recognize this as a critical period in life, when the child learns that other people have their own thoughts and their own needs. Children are gradually drawn into group interaction, and begin to learn how to work with others. It's at this point that Vilani society begins teaching its distinctive ways to its newest members.

Education

On Terra, the education system is geared toward the acquisition of knowledge, the socialization of children, and the development of problem-solving skills. The Imperium's schools are much the same, with the notable exception of *not* teaching their children how to solve problems themselves.

To a Vilani, "problem-solving" is equivalent to "finding out what others have done." They learn how to resolve difficulties by relying on the development of group consensus and investigation of historical databases for previously successful procedures.

To a Terran observer, Vilani classes look like throwbacks to an earlier age. Students of similar age gather physically in the same room, as opposed to using computer-aided tele-education and proceeding at their own pace. From the earliest age, children are taught to work together, the stronger students assisting the weaker ones so that the group as a whole attains its goals. Children are also exposed to a wide variety of tasks, so that everyone has the experience of being a leader as well as needing help from others.

Classes mix students from different social classes; the goal is to get children used to working with people who are not their friends or social equals. Once students have mastered the basic skills (the Vilani equivalent of elementary school), they are segregated somewhat in order to give members of each social stratum training specific to their expected position in life. However, even in the final years of school, all students, highborn and low alike, will share a few courses. After graduation, it's expected that a Vilani will be able to work with his equals, take instruction from his superiors, and give instruction to his subordinates – all smoothly and without resentment.

The Class System

Every Vilani citizen falls into one of three social classes: *engarii*, *damgarii*, and *enshii*. These very old Vilani words are usually translated as “commoners,” “merchants,” and “nobles.” Of course, any translation from Vilani to English is difficult, and this one is looser than most. It gives the sense of a feudal society, which the Imperium most certainly is not. Another way to translate the three names of the social groups might be “employees,” “managers,” and “executives.” These translations, while not exact, better reflect the way Vilani interact in a technologically advanced, industrial society.

All three classes are hereditary. Children are assumed to be worthy of the same status as their parents unless they clearly show they aren’t. No stigma attaches to mixed marriage, but in such cases, children are assigned the status of the lower-class parent at birth.

It’s important to note that even in this late and somewhat ossified period, there is still mobility between the classes. Most Vilani start out their careers in the class to which they are born, but promotion is always a possibility, and the most promising children may be raised a class immediately after completing school. Vilani society depends on this mobility as its primary way of channeling natural Human acquisitiveness and competitiveness. It’s also an important tool for preventing people from acting badly – as well as promotions, there are demotions.

Engarii, commoners, or “employees” are by far the most numerous group of Vilani. They make up the workaday people who go to their jobs, do what they’re told, then go home at night with few large thoughts in their heads. *Engarii* form the bulk of the so-called “Low Vilani” culture (p. 15). Enlisted men and NCOs in the military are usually *engarii*.

Members of the *damgarii*, or “manager,” class are almost entirely the industrial “petty nobility” – allied with the great industrialists of the distant past, but not as rich or successful in the present. Managers fill the positions of junior and mid-level officers in the military, and virtually all scientists

are manager-class, too. *Damgarii* run the day-to-day operations of the *shangarim*.

The modern ruling class is an amalgam of three different groups. The first group is the original *enshii* class, derived from the aristocratic rulers of Vland’s earliest agricultural towns.

The second group is the *shugilii*. Native life on Vland is almost incompatible with Human biochemistry; without careful preparation most foods are toxic. Beginning in prehistoric times, the *shugilii* caste developed (and hoarded) safe methods for food preparation, on which society came to depend. With advanced technology and interstellar trade the need for these secret techniques declined, but the *shugilii* retained a role as the guardians of tradition, the closest thing Vilani society had to a priestly caste.

Finally, there is a group of wealthy industrialist clans, who derive both wealth and status from times prior to the Consolidation Wars. Over the last 3,000 years, these three groups have melded, though there are still minor differences between them.

Early in Vilani history, each subgroup of the *enshii* class established one of the three great *shangarim*, or “bureaus.” To this day, each portion of the ruling class tends to gravitate into certain sections of the Imperial government. Descendants of the original *enshii* tend toward the officer class of the Army and Navy, and control the

shangarim Makhidkarun. The *shugilii* caste controls Naasirka. The industrialists run Sharurshid (p. 14).

The ruling class contributes its best members to the *Igsiirdi*, the actual ruling council of the Imperium, which provides the closest thing the Vilani have to a career in pure politics. The *Igsiirdi* in turn selects the *Ishimkarun* or “Shadow Emperor.”

Careers

In Vilani society, there are few career changes. It is assumed that a person will pick a career at age 14 (18 Terran years), use the last few years of his schooling to prepare for that profession, and then stick with it until the end of his working life. This lack of movement has led to the common translation of the Vilani word *ii* as “caste.” This is something of a misnomer, since there’s no requirement for any citizen to have the same career as his parents. Indeed, youngsters are actively encouraged to look for work outside their parents’ professions, as a check against nepotism.

Social class most often dictates career choice. Careers are assigned to each social class based on the amount of leadership required, so a young citizen needs to pick something appropriate to his class unless he is specifically chosen as promising (or hopeless) during school. Of course, any profession that is normally organized in a hierarchical manner will need the participation of people from different social classes.



Classes and Careers

In many cases, a Terran with only a vague idea of Vilani social structure can guess at an occupation's class. There are cases where historical accident or confusion with the *Terran* status of a career can be confusing. Several common professions and their associated social classes:

Artist or entertainer: Commoner

Doctor or surgeon: Executive (the medical profession derives from the ancient *shugilii* caste)

Engineer or technician: Commoner

Factory worker: Commoner

Merchant captain: Manager

Merchant deck hand: Commoner (even including highly trained technicians)

Military enlisted man: Commoner

Military junior officer: Manager

Military senior or "flag" officer: Executive

Police officer: Commoner

Scientist: Commoner

Once ready to begin work, a new adult is seconded to an older person in the same profession. He remains under this mentor's tutelage until that person dies, is promoted, or specifically resigns in favor of his charge. This last option often occurs when it becomes obvious that the apprentice is a prodigy; it normally takes no more than 20 years to discover this fact.

The Vilani have no strict concept of seniority. When it becomes necessary to reorganize a group of workers, it is the responsibility of the group's leader to design the new organization and recommend his design to his own superiors. Even sudden death is no excuse, as a leader is supposed to have instructions at the ready for this event (leading to Terran jokes about "Last Will and Departmental Restructuring" documents). It is assumed that the reorganization will take place solely on the basis of competence, not on "time in grade" or any other measure of seniority.

Retirement

A Vilani's working life starts to come to an end on his 85th birthday (about 110 Terran years). On that day he starts working three days in six rather than the usual four. The next year, this drops to two, and so on. From age 88 to 90 (about the age of

115 to 118 Terran years), he is merely an irregular consultant to his successor. After his 91st birthday (about 119 Terran years), he is out of the workforce entirely, and is supported by a basic stipend made available to all retired citizens, the luxury of which depends on his position while younger.

Of course, while they may stop working, older Vilani aren't lacking for responsibilities to fulfill. In particular, they are the caretakers of their extended family's youngest children, yet another piece of social engineering designed to instill young Vilani with trust in authority.

VILANI CULTURE

Trading is about value, and value (once you get past the basics of life) depends very much on culture. Terrans who intend to work in Imperial society need to understand what drives the Vilani when they're not working.

Visual Arts

Vilani art is at the same time very abstract and very literal. Their visual art and decoration bears some resemblance to the classical Muslim art of Terra, with an emphasis on repeating geometric figures. The difference is that despite the similarity in form, there is no *metaphor* in modern Vilani art. Medieval Muslims used abstraction in order to get around a religious stricture against representative images; the figures were intended to "be" something despite not literally looking like that thing. In Vilani painting and sculpture, a square is just a square.

In fact, the current style developed just before the Consolidation Wars, at a time when the symbols of Vilani art were as complex and meaningful as anything produced by a Terran culture. In the intervening 3,000 years, however, the "symbols" have become independent of their original meanings; artists keep using them because that's what is done, not because they have something to say with them.

Paradoxically, this makes art very accessible to the Vilani masses.

The Vilani are crazy for geometric figures. I remember one I had to chaperone in Paris; we spent two hours in the Louvre and she didn't like a single thing. Eventually we ended up at an old amusement park on the outskirts of the city – and she declared this rundown hedge maze we went through to be the finest piece of Terran art she'd seen.

– Vincent Royce,
Ministry of Commerce official (3021)

Museums and galleries are popular entertainments for even the lowest-class employee – there's nothing to understand, you just look and enjoy. This makes *objets d'art* a favorite trade good, though it's difficult to predict in advance what will appeal to a Vilani. For example, they don't see the point of painting real-world objects: "Why not just use a photograph or hologram?"

Conversely, Terran abstract art is considered either interesting or so horribly "wrong" that it provokes laughter. For example, most Vilani find Jackson Pollock merely amusing, while geometric artists like Piet Mondrian are accepted as fine art.

Athletics

Like Terrans, Vilani enjoy testing their physical limits, but a quick examination of Vilani sports shows that they choose their adversaries carefully. Competing as an individual is distasteful; while such sports existed in the past, no one plays them any more. Instead, the Vilani stick to team sports, or individual sports where the competition is impersonal.

As an example of the latter, the Vilani play *uskamsii*, a game with a remarkable resemblance to golf – one uses a club outdoors to drive a small ball towards a distant target in a minimal number of shots. Vilani view the *uskamsii* course itself as the opponent,

with the odd side effect that they prefer to stick to the same course for every game rather than trying different challenges. When they play in groups, they invariably play "best ball," with the group scoring according to the best performance among the players. Construction of an *uskamsii* course is expensive, and access to one is restricted to manager-class or better. One trade item that is very popular among Vilani commoners is a dedicated handheld computer game that simulates Terran golf.

Team games are deliberately cooperative, possibly as an attempt to obscure the fact that one team is deliberately trying to defeat the other. The most popular such game in the

Imperium is *duriir*, which is played on a field shaped like two wedges pointing at one another. The wedges are divided into five zones, each containing a player. The object is to make the ball (hit with rackets) fall in the opposing team's wedge – the further in, the more points. The twist is that only the player in the wedge's "point" is allowed to knock the ball into the other side. The other players defend against the lobs of the opposing team's "point man," and work to knock the ball back to their own point player. In a way, the game resembles Terran volleyball, with the distant players working the ball forward a step at a time until the player at the front can smash it towards the territory of the other team.

Vilani Longevity

The Vilani are much longer lived than Terran Humans. Barring illness or injury, a Vilani citizen can expect to reach an age of 130 Terran years, and some Vilani live for more than another half century past that.

This is yet one more factor that lends stability to the Imperium. Despite working for nearly 100 Terran years, a citizen will still draw goods from the economy for several more decades after that. This has the effect of slowing economic growth, as so much production is siphoned off for the elderly. Of course, as is typical for the Imperium, this is considered a point in the retirement system's favor and not a drawback.

Vilani longevity apparently breeds true. People of mixed Vilani-Terran parentage already show signs of extended vigor and health. The few people of mixed heritage who were born prior to 2070 are routinely clearing their century mark.

Vilani Architecture

Vilani architecture is much like the other Vilani art forms – oddly familiar to a Terran visitor, but different enough to seem alien.

The buildings themselves are massive, blocky, and monumental. Terrans often describe the prevalent style as a mix between Babylonian ziggurats and mid-20th century Russian concrete triumphalism. There is not much adornment or ostentation. What decoration there is serves to remind the observer of the sober ideals of the Imperium: collectivism, efficiency, and respect for the past.

Most cities are built on a radial plan, with long boulevards down which gravitic vehicles travel. The boulevards are also very wide, with grass (or at least an unused area) down the center to give vehicles a place to put down in case of an emergency. Pedestrian sidewalks (or slidewalks in richer or larger cities) run along both edges of the street.

Vilani cities are planned under the assumption that most transport traffic will be communal rather than private. Only high-ranking manager or executive-class citizens will own their own ground cars or air/rafts. Depending on the distance to be traveled, a Vilani commoner will take a "people carrier" or use the slidewalk until he gets near his destination, at which point he hops off and walks along a side road to his goal.

Vilani buildings are almost always square or rectangular, which means that when combined with a city's radial layout, there are innumerable triangular bits of land left over. This is deliberate; the leftover space is used for parks and other public facilities. From the air, Vilani cities are checkered with green or whatever other color the local flora favors, despite the massive, boxy buildings.

THE VILANI IMPERIUM

The Imperium is so vast that it's difficult to conceive just how big it really is. The very fastest Imperial courier services require about *two years* to carry a message from the rimward frontier to Vland. A more typical traveler would take over *five years* to make the same journey – and to reach the Imperium's coreward frontier, even more time would be needed.

During Terran history, empires have always been limited by the time it took for instructions to go from the center to the edge. Terran empires that were more than six months “across” have never lasted very long. The Vilani have therefore come up with something completely unfamiliar to Terran observers – a political system that can hold itself together despite huge problems with communication.

POLITICAL ORGANIZATION

The Imperium is organized as a star, with the Shadow Emperor at the center. The three *shangarim* and two military services are linked to him and him alone. There is no official channel permitting the five power groups to

negotiate directly with one another, and indeed any such negotiation is considered treasonable. This has peculiar effects on the day-to-day operations of the empire, as always reinforcing its stability and changelessness.

The Shadow Emperor

There are many things impeding change in the Imperium, but if one is most important it's this: the *Ishimkarun* or “Shadow Emperor” is the sole source of law.

At first sight this seems contradictory. The Terran experience indicates that a dictatorship can change more quickly than a democracy, as there's no need to “play politics” when it comes time to make a decision. However, even on Terra there have been cases of absolutism in which things were almost unmanageable, because *every* decision had to go through one person. There's a fine balance between centralization and delegating when it comes to getting things done, and as always the *Ziru Sirka* was specifically designed to slow things down.

The key to this is that the Shadow Emperor's day only has 32 hours, the same as even the poorest subject on Vland. With the events of thousands of worlds swirling around him, it is far beyond the realm of possibility that he could affect more than the tiniest fraction of them.

The Vilani solution to this problem is not delegation, but *precedent*. Every *Ishimkarun* has over 3,000 years of rulings from his predecessors to fall back on. Until he specifically authorizes a change to a previous decision, that precedent rules. Procedure is followed because, once upon a time, it was the law laid down by some near-forgotten Emperor to deal with a similar situation. Fortunately, the system of precedents is highly refined, and since the *Ziru Sirka* has been so static, it can cover almost everything. However, when something novel happens, it can take a long time for the message to get to the Imperium's “head” and for the response to return.

When a new situation arises, or if an old law needs revising, it is the duty of the *shangarim* and the military services to bring it to the Emperor's attention. More to the point, they must *try* to bring it to his attention.

Even with the vast majority of matters handled by following precedent, there are still far too many things for the Emperor to examine. The five points of the “star” surrounding him have to compete for his time, struggling to gain the minutes needed to outline the problem, advise the Emperor on the solution, possibly wait for him to consult with outside experts, and then make a change to the established procedure. Only the most critical matters are raised, and on everything else the affected persons have to make do.

Naturally, in such a system the ultimate sign of Imperial disapproval is the loss of the Emperor's attention. For example, if one of the *shangarim* begins to act up, the Emperor only has to make his displeasure known for the other four groups to have a field day. They divide the disapproved *shangarim*'s “face time” among themselves, thereby getting more of their own agendas advanced. They can

Vilani Dissidents and Secret Societies

There are no dissidents in Vilani space. Ask any Vilani – he'll tell you so, loudly and emphatically.

The primary purpose of the Imperium is to get everyone to toe the line, reducing strife and so maximizing happiness. Unfortunately this purpose contains a fundamental flaw: it assumes that everyone will be happy with the same thing. Despite the best efforts of Vilani society to instill love for the way things are, mistakes will be made, and sometimes sheer Human contrariness will leave someone dissatisfied. If only one person feels this way, he usually stays very quiet. If two of them get together, they form a secret society.

In the Imperium's core, the police are well-funded, and are very good at finding and dealing with the “socially ill.” Out on the Rim, the level of control is much lower. Secret societies of all sorts have popped up and maintain a precarious existence. While they are difficult to find by definition, a Terran who can plug into one and cater to its needs can turn a tidy profit – and crack open the Imperium just a little bit more for the next trader to come along.

also start to cheat the outcast group with impunity. Shipments arrive with defective parts, if they arrive at all; prices are raised; promising recruits are poached. The only recourse is to get the Emperor to stop it, and the Emperor won't even listen to the black sheep until it comes back into line.

The only remaining danger to the Emperor's authority is the creation of *ad hoc* connections between the points of the star. For the Imperial system to work, everything must go through the Emperor. As a result, communications between the *shangarim* and the military are very restricted. It is possible for a *shangarim* official to take direct command of military units in the field, but the necessary protocols are so restrictive that only the most talented bureaucrats can accomplish much. Most *shangarim* executives content themselves with outlining strategic goals for their province, letting the military figure out how to attain those goals.

Sharurshid

Of the three bureaus, the one most likely to be encountered by Terrans on a day-to-day basis is Sharurshid, the Vilani shipping and trading concern. This is not only because it is engaged in the business likeliest to get adventurers into the Imperium – buying and selling – but also because it's in control of the space closest to Terra.

It's fortunate for the Terran Confederation that Sharurshid is its neighbor. As the *shangarim* most used to commerce and transport, it was the likeliest to accept Terran overtures to trade. While relations can be frosty at times, the potential for profitable transactions always brings Sharurshid back to the table. If Terra had been next to Makhidkarun, with its more authoritarian style, things might have been very different.

The protocols controlling communication between the various agencies are very deep – once again, the benefit of 3,000 years of refinement – but they quite specifically avoid topics that could let two or more factions conspire against the throne. Communication outside the approved protocols is high treason, and the factions are always on the lookout for signs that their competitors are engaging in it. The one item that is guaranteed to draw the Emperor's attention immediately is evidence of extra-legal communication, and coming up with such evidence invariably leads him to examine more of the loyal branch's issues for a while afterwards.

the council is the power base on which the Speakers rely to define the agenda for their presentations to the *Ishimkarun*. Members of the *Igsiirdi* tend to fall into factions behind different Speakers, making up informal political parties that push different viewpoints within their own factions.

The other major role of the *Igsiirdi* is the selection of the new Emperor upon the death of the previous one. When the Emperor dies, all *Igsiirdi* members capable of doing so are expected to report to the Imperial Palace on Vland, where the death is announced and three days of mutual consultation begin. At the end of the three days, each segment of the

The Emperor doesn't rule the Imperium. No one does. They think the ghosts of ten trillion dead Vilani will rise up out of their graves if anyone ever has an original thought.

– Juan Santiago, *Imperial Years*

The Igsiirdi

The *Igsiirdi* is composed of representatives of the branches of Imperial government, who advise the Emperor and try to get Imperial legislation passed on their behalf. Strictly speaking, the *Igsiirdi* has 300 members, but only 15 “Speakers” are authorized to talk directly to the Emperor – one each for the Army and Navy, three for each of the *shangarim*, and four “members at large” appointed by the current Emperor. The remainder of

Igsiirdi (the three *shangarim*, the Army, the Navy, and the Emperor-appointed faction) puts forward a candidate. This nomination process usually produces six names, but sometimes more than one faction will put forward the same name.

Voting then begins – openly, it should be noted, not by secret ballot – in a series of rounds. After each round of voting, the candidate receiving the least votes is dropped from the ballot. The process continues until one candidate obtains a majority of the votes. At this point, one more ritualized vote is held with only that person on the ballot, so that the new Emperor is always formally elected with 100% of the vote.

The Shangarim

The *shangarim*, or “bureaus,” are three huge agencies that manage the day-to-day operations of the Imperium. Taken as a bloc, they are the single largest faction in the *Igsiirdi*, though they often vote at cross-purposes.

Each of the *shangarim* stems from a specific power group in early Vilani society aristocrats, *shugilii*, and industrialists. Not long after the Vilani began expanding into space, the power of each of these groups was threatened; their response was to reorganize the government along corporate lines. Each group established one of the *shangarim* as a overarching corporate bureaucracy. Each of the bureaus was then handed a territory to run; these spheres of influence were largely distinct, although in a few regions they overlapped in complex ways. Despite the enormous dislocations of the Consolidation Wars, the three *shangarim* have hung onto power ever since.

Makhidkarun is the aristocratic agency, specializing in services often associated with government on Terran worlds. Police, media, infrastructure, and similar services are under its control, or licensed to the other *shangarim*. Its primary territory is the area around Vland.

Sharurshid is the industrialist *shangarim*. Its areas of interest are the production and distribution of goods, and the continuing development of colonies as markets. All unarmed ships in the Imperium belong to Sharurshid, so while this agency formally owns the territories near the Terran Confederation, it can be found operating anywhere the Vilani go.

Naasirka is the bureau derived from the *shugilii* caste. At first solely concerned with food production, it has branched out into other “basics,” notably energy production and distribution.

IMPERIAL ADMINISTRATION

With huge travel times between Vland and the Rim (or any other frontier for that matter), the Imperium depends on its hierarchy. In many ways, it's organized like a Terran corporation, with “vice-presidents” and “upper management” and “middle management” controlling successively smaller political divisions. It's important to note, in particular, that none of them *rule* a domain – they *manage* them. They are completely answerable

to the people higher up in the hierarchy, and even to the Emperor (though in practice the *Ishimkarun* rarely pays attention to anyone more than a level below). Every manager has a book to follow, and is more bureaucrat than noble.

The Imperial Hierarchy

The highest rank in the Vilani ruling class is that of *Ishimkarun*, or “Shadow Emperor.” He is selected by the *Igsiirdi*, and serves for life or until he chooses to abdicate (which almost never happens). The Emperor lives in extreme seclusion; he never appears in public, and aside from his own family and household staff he almost never meets with anyone other than the 15 Speakers of the *Igsiirdi*.

Beneath the Shadow Emperor stands a set of 12 *apkallu kibrat arban* (“Great Ministers of the Four Quarters”). This title is one of extreme antiquity, and appears to be from a dialect of Vilani that is now otherwise extinct. The title denotes a position of immense power, and is reserved for the leaders of the *shangarim* and their highest assistants. Each of these nobles oversees the activities of his bureau over at least 2-4 sectors. In most cases, the power of the *apkallu kibrat arban* is limited to grand strategy – the sheer size of a noble's domain at this level prevents much control over the details of government operation. Another informal name for these nobles is *karunii* (“petty emperors”).

The title of *saarpuhii* (“underking”) appears to derive from the various nation-states that existed on Vland before spaceflight. Today a *saarpuhii* oversees a substantial portion of a single sector, usually 80-150 worlds in all. A *saarpuhii* on the Imperial frontier is the official most likely to hold strategic control over local wars, overseeing punitive expeditions against rebels or barbarians. The *saarpuhii* whose domain is closest to Terra is the *Saarpuhii Kushuggi* (“Underking of the Rim Worlds”).

Below the *Saarpuhii Kushuggi* are 10 *sarriiu* (“supreme governors”), who oversee about a dozen worlds apiece. Each subsector's capital is usually the seat of a *sarriiu* with unusually high prestige. There are normally 2-4 lesser *sarriiu* per subsector as well.

The *sarriiu* in turn are supported by *shakkanakhu* (“provincial governors”), who appear to occupy a very flexible level in the bureaucracy. A *shakkanakhu* normally governs 3-6 worlds – but in one known case, a *shakkanakhu* in the Kushuggi province clearly manages more worlds and people than the weakest *sarriiu* of the area. It's not entirely clear why this is the case, but there's reason to believe that the political subdivision of provinces can be quite fluid if something is upsetting the situation. Apparently the Terran Confederation is doing just that, and things are being reorganized in odd ways according to needs perceived by the current *saarpuhii*.

The business end of Imperial government can be found at the lowest level of the hierarchy that is routinely a week or more away from its superiors. These *iishakku* (“governors”) each get a planet to manage, or sometimes part of a particularly populous or important planet. Most citizens will deal with the local *iishakku* or his staff, if they need to interact with the Imperium at all.

All of the above titles are hereditary. Vilani noble families employ a rule of inheritance that is very unusual by Terran standards: only the *third* and later children are eligible to inherit a noble's hereditary titles, and adoption for the purpose of obtaining an heir is not permitted. A noble's first and second children are still members of the executive class, but they must earn new titles for themselves. It's routine



for a noble family to lose a hereditary position for lack of any legal heir, forcing the family's superiors to choose a new clan to hold the position. This causes a certain amount of "churn" in the Imperium's upper hierarchy, preventing any one family from monopolizing power.

Below the rank of *iishakku* comes the bulk of the Imperial ruling class, the pool of potential leaders from which the *shangarim* and the military services can draw. There is a bewildering variety of non-hereditary titles at this level, indicating the degree and kind of authority held by each individual. It can be particularly difficult for Terrans to navigate the lower Imperial hierarchy, even if the titles themselves are properly translated – is a "Third Minister for Quality Control" senior to an "Undersecretary of Employee Relations," or the other way around?

One non-hereditary title that does occur frequently is that of *kiduunuuzii* ("holder of special privileges"). This title is awarded to particularly effective leaders, including "troubleshooters" who have a history of solving problems wherever they go. The title of *kiduunuuzii* is even awarded to very talented members of the manager class, often as a preliminary to granting hereditary noble status.

Colonies vs. Outposts

There are about 10,000 star systems in the area of space controlled by the Imperium. Of these, about 4,000 include planets inhabited by substantial Vilani populations, and another 4,000 contain outposts of some kind. The rest are simply empty systems contained within the Vilani sphere, but otherwise of no note at all.

The Vilani don't colonize "difficult" or inhospitable worlds unless there is something else compelling about them. Sometimes this is a resource, but most often the attractive feature is sheer location – the system is a necessary stopping point along a route from one place to another, and the Vilani had to pick *somewhere* in the system to put their facilities. These are Imperial *outposts*, and they're different from Vilani worlds in a number of important ways.

Most obviously, they are much less densely populated, and much less

diverse than a proper Imperial colony. Nearly everyone living there is, at least indirectly, connected with servicing passing traffic or performing whatever other intended function the outpost may have.

be more familiar with the concept of trade than your average Vilani on a more hospitable world.

The final difference is that the population mixture is often odd. Vilani colonies are just that: *Vilani* colonies.

You know, if we behaved ourselves, I think the Vilani are so complacent they'd let us colonize all the empty worlds in their Imperium, from one end to the other. Good thing I have no intention of being a good boy by their standards, just so I can breathe canned air for the rest of my life.

– Bill Rodriguez, Nusku colonist (3025)

This makes an outpost more cosmopolitan than a colony, as the world's citizens are used to dealing with people from outside the community. They're often more tolerant of difference too, though this is a matter of degree as compared to their colonial brethren rather than actual toleration. If nothing else, people on outposts will

There are many other races in the Imperium, but with the exception of the Vegans (p. 88), none of them are the majority on any world within easy reach of Terra. On outposts, however, it's not unusual to see members of the more important subject races, particularly the Suerrat (p. 86).

Vilani Settlement Patterns

For the entire, glorious period leading up to the Consolidation Wars, the Vilani had their choice of worlds. With only a few exceptions, such as Geonee and Suerrat space, no one else laid any claim to a significant number of planets.

As a result, Vilani colonists were quite choosy, and the majority of Vilani colony worlds are reasonably Terran (or, rather "Vland-like"). The Vilani started substantial colonies on less hospitable planets only when a valuable resource beckoned, or a bridge was needed between two important colony areas.

Similarly, there has never been any reason to let planetary populations get out of hand: there is always more land out there somewhere, and the benevolent Imperial government is willing to move people to new colonies in the unlikely event that they wish to. There are still empty worlds well worth living on throughout Imperial space. Even the most populous worlds, barring Vland itself, rarely have more than a few billion citizens.

Still, a merchant run down a Vilani-inhabited main is something of a hit-or-miss proposition. By sheer random chance, several "good" worlds will sometimes be lined up, with markets of hundreds of millions to tap, while a run of bad luck will turn up minor outposts and empty star systems stretching for parsecs.

SUBJECT RACES

While it's common to use the term "Vilani Imperium," it's important to remember that the Vilani are not the only intelligent species under its rule. About 10% of the Imperial population are Humans of other stock, no more Vilani than they are Terran. Another 10% are alien species, with no biological ties to Humans at all.

As far as possible, the Vilani try to integrate these races into Imperial society, but for a variety of reasons this effort isn't always successful.

First, many were brought into the Imperium by force. Thousands of years may have worn off the worst of the sting, but a few races that were once only moderately less powerful than the Vilani still remember their glory days.

In fact, the Vilani are stubborn about their crusade to bring "good government" to the rest of the galaxy. Only the really hopeless cases get blockaded or interdicted; the Imperium will keep banging its head against the wall if there's the slightest chance that a race will come around to the Vilani way of life. This means that the Imperium has to deal with uprisings every now and then – but it normally enjoys an overwhelming advantage over such rebels. Client revolts are rarely more than small hurdles in the way of the Vilani obsession with making everyone else just like them.

few non-Vilani races to occasionally hold high positions in the government.

History

Little is known about early Anakundu history. At some point the race was apparently reduced to a very small population, causing a genetic "bottleneck" that has left them in the throes of a serious evolutionary dead end.

The Anakundu were first contacted by the Vilani about 4,000 years ago. At that time there were only a few tens of thousands of them, living in small hunter-gatherer groups on one of their home world's continents.

Primitive and unthreatening, the Anakundu received aid from the Imperium so that they could be incorporated into galactic civilization. Among the Vilani coming to Nuiya were medical doctors, who soon noticed that the Anakundu had a short maximum lifespan, even setting aside deaths caused by their primitive state. Eventually the Vilani developed a drug that let the Anakundu live somewhat longer; out of amazement at the "magic" their benefactors possessed, they willingly became Vilani clients.

For the last 2,000 years the Anakundu have enjoyed equal status with the Vilani, though they are heavily outnumbered by their allies. They live entirely by Vilani culture, and have nothing but disdain for the primitive ways of their ancestors.

Physiology

Externally, the Anakundu look much like Vilani or Terrans. Their home continent on Nuiya was in the extreme north, so they are usually very pale. The major exception is around their eyes. Their homeworld's primary star is quite bright, and their snowy home environment made for a great deal of glare. As an adaptation, Anakundu eyes are black, surrounded by a dense spray of freckles that reduce reflection from the cheekbones.

The most unusual aspect of the Anakundu is their sleeplessness and associated short lifespan. As an



There are also aliens that simply can't be integrated, for reasons of psychology or physical difference. Some such aliens are actively blockaded onto their home worlds, with Imperial naval squadrons to ensure that they launch no expeditions into space. Others are still primitive, and are "interdicted" – shielded by the Navy from all outside contact.

ANAKUNDU

The Anakundu are a minor Human race native to Nuiya, in the Mikadira sector. They were at a Neolithic level of development when the Vilani came, lifting them to modern conditions over the next 1,000 years. Since then they have been staunch allies of the Imperium, and in fact are one of the

infant, an Anakundu sleeps six or seven hours per night; he will gradually lose another hour for every 10 Terran years of life. While they have adapted somewhat to this condition, there are fundamental limits reached at about two hours of sleep. Without medical intervention, at some point between 45 and 50 Terran years of age, an Anakundu will drop rapidly into mute senescence, insanity, then death.

The Imperium treats this condition with *gakinisharra*, a drug that slows the process and holds off the two-hour limit until age 75-80. While still tragically short by Vilani standards, this lifespan has been all the Anakundu could expect for thousands of years, and they do not look for more.

It is worth noting that the Anakundu sleep deficit resembles some Terran chromosome disorders. It is believed within Confederation medical circles that their condition could be cured with gene therapy. Vilani medical science has not advanced to this stage, however, and no Anakundu has ever submitted to the tests that would be needed to establish the truth.

Psychology

Fatalism and subordination are the two main prongs of Anakundu culture. They never recovered from the shock of being contacted by a vastly more advanced Human race. While they have long since caught up with the Vilani and become Imperial partners, their continuing deficit in lifespan makes them feel inferior to this day. Most Anakundu accept their "fate," and live their lives accordingly. This attitude spills over into other things, so it's virtually unheard of for an Anakundu to complain about anything. Even the normal Human desire to make things better is muted; an Anakundu must be suffering more from, say, cold or hunger before he becomes motivated to try and solve the problem.

On the other hand, Anakundu follow orders willingly. They are especially valued for their ability to stay awake for 20 consecutive hours at will, and more than twice as long with minimal difficulty. The Imperial

Army is especially fond of them as ground troops, valuing their stoicism and stamina.

Anakundu in the Interstellar Wars

If it weren't for their extremely pale skin and their freckled "eye-shades," one might never realize that an Anakundu is not a Vilani. They have adopted Vilani language, and live entirely within Vilani culture. Although their short lifespans tend to limit their promotion in Vilani society, Anakundu can be found even in the Imperial executive class.

Most often, a Terran will discover the difference by bumping up against Anakundu sleeplessness. Running across a pale, black-eyed ghost in the dark of night, when everyone else is asleep, is a memorable experience. Sometimes an Anakundu will specifically use the wee hours to get away with something under the noses of dreaming Terrans.

Terran soldiers often call the Anakundu the "night-fighters" or "spooks," and hold them in considerable respect. The average Terran doesn't know about the Anakundu racial weaknesses. They just know that these slender troopers are brave, determined, and can win an engagement just by staying awake and shooting long after their Terran foes have collapsed from exhaustion.

ANSWERIN

The Answerin are a Human race, much like Terrans or the Vilani. Unlike some Human races, they are difficult to distinguish from the two main types of Human, but they possess unusual internal changes, and a psychology to match.

History

Not much is known about the Answerin, as they live far to coreward of Terra – in fact, it is believed that they hail from near Vland itself. Most Answerin met by Terrans are soldiers, so detailed questioning is often difficult.

Still, it is known that they encountered the Vilani fairly early on, before the founding of the *Ziru Sirka*. Their civilization was primitive, so they rapidly acquired that of the Vilani at a

time when that process was much less painful. When the *Ziru Sirka* began, their home world was peacefully annexed, and the Answerin have been loyal subjects ever since.

Physiology

The average Answerin is 3" taller than a Terran or Vilani, and somewhat heavier, although slimmer in proportion due to his greater height. His world's twin suns are heavy emitters of ultraviolet light, so even the lightest-skinned Answerin is dark by Terran standards, and many are black in the literal sense of the word. Their hair is invariably black too, and usually slightly wavy; a few have straight hair. Their only unusual facial feature is a pronounced epicanthic fold in the manner of Terran East Asians, an adaptation to the strong light in which they developed.

What makes the Answerin unusual among known Humans is their ability to consciously trigger adrenaline surges, which enhance their strength and speed for approximately a minute. Once the minute is over, they are debilitated for the next hour. This conscious control over an involuntary "fear" reaction has had a profound effect on their psychology and culture.

Psychology

The Answerin are very interested in self-control, particularly control of fear. They do have emotions, showing happiness, anger, love, and so on when there is no reason to suppress them. Fear, however, is viewed as a mental illness, and the Answerin have spent the last 3,000 years trying to cure it.

Answerin culture is structured around keeping fear from becoming an issue, partly through removing causes, and partly through carefully cultivating personal bravery as part of their lives. They're not insensitive to danger, but they believe that an irrational response to it is counterproductive. During their lives, they bend every effort toward learning how to stay calm and continue functioning when every other Human race would be wasting mental resources battling fear, or would have given in to the emotion entirely.

Answerin in the Interstellar Wars

Their unique psychology makes the Answerin very useful as soldiers, and many members of their race are in the Imperium's armed forces. Many Answerin are in other professions, but Terran Humans almost never encounter these members of the race.

An Answerin soldier's adrenaline surge makes him doubly dangerous. Terrans often call Answerin "berserkers," despite the fact that they are invariably quite calm while punching holes through walls, overturning cars, and otherwise doing things no Human has any right doing. They are greatly

They obtained this status by having unparalleled heads for bureaucratic detail, which gives them the ability to take on fussy management jobs that even Vilani find difficult.

History

Originally hailing from the world of Marhaban, the Newts had begun their Industrial Revolution when they were first contacted by the Vilani. This was before the Consolidation Wars, and the Bwaps picked up Vilani technology with great speed, coming up to a par with their Human visitors within 100 years.



feared in wartime – although it's worth noting that this is a *respectful* fear, as most Terran soldiers also admire Answerin strengths.

Fortunately, while Answerin are grouped into their own units, they are commanded by Vilani, so they are stuck with fossilized tactics that make them vulnerable. Every time war breaks out, the Terran forces are armed with a whole new set of clever ideas for getting the Answerin to "burn off" their surges, rendering them useless for combat afterwards. It's to Answerin credit that Terrans *do* have to come up with new ideas every time; the Answerin are rarely taken in more than once by any given gambit.

BWAPS

Of all the Imperial subject races, the Bwaps (also called "Newts" by most Terrans) are the most successful.

The Bwaps soon had a small interstellar state of their own, but when the *Ziru Sirka* was proclaimed they voluntarily joined the new empire. The Imperium's ideals of order and stability appealed to them greatly, and they threw themselves into the new project. Over time, they became the most useful Vilani partner in the running of the Imperium, and have spread throughout the entire state.

Physiology

The Bwaps are 4' to 5' in height and bipedal, but otherwise have a superficial resemblance to the Terran creatures that supplied their nickname. Like Terran newts, they are amphibious, and they do require high levels of humidity to protect their skins. In most Human facilities they will wear special robes and head-cloths that draw water from small attached tanks.

If the humidity drops below 20%, however, even that stopgap starts to fail, and a Newt will have to wear a full environment suit in what is otherwise a perfectly hospitable place.

Bwap eyes are large and apparently pupil-less, being entirely a shiny black. Their skins, always damp, are dark green and blue. They sport complex color patterns, some of them natural, some applied with waterproof paints to act as markers of social status and position.

Females are outnumbered 10-to-1 by males, and are sequestered on Bwap colony worlds, so all Bwaps encountered by Terrans are male.

Psychology

Newts are focused on hierarchy and procedure, an attitude that sometimes makes them "more Vilani than the Vilani." The Imperium's founders acknowledged that the society that they were creating ran counter to some deep Human motivations, but that is not the case with the Newts. Of all the races ruled by the *Ziru Sirka*, they are the most psychologically suited to it.

Conceptually, the Bwaps view the world as *Wapawab*, the tree of life, with everything connected to everything else, and everyone performing a function for the good of the whole. Each tries to place himself and others in that tree and then interact in an appropriate manner. In particular, they have a fondness for being the "cogs in the machine." This means that the majority of them encountered by Terrans are bureaucrats, trying to keep things in order. Or, as some Terrans have put it: "They think the Imperium's a tree, and it's their duty to keep us saps running."

Balancing out their fetish for bureaucracy is their incorruptibility. As part of insisting that every rule be followed, they would never dream of "polluting the water" by taking a bribe or looking the other way. As the Imperium is designed to run smoothly if the rules are followed, a Bwap can be your best friend when dealing with the Vilani, a bulwark against the corruption that is shot through the system.

On the other hand, if you're a rule-breaker, they can make your life impossibly difficult.

Bwaps in the Interstellar Wars

As well as being common sights in the Imperial bureaucracy, Bwaps are found wherever their peculiar knack for detail can come in handy. This includes systems maintenance, from as high-profile as heading a starport traffic control system to as lowly as janitorial work. They are also common on water worlds, where not only can they help run things, they can go underwater for long periods of time to work on niggling problems.

Bwaps are also commonly encountered in criminal investigations. Despite their reputation for focusing on the small things, they are as imaginative as Humans when it comes to interpreting data, and their dogged ability to check every possibility makes them effective, if slow, forensic officers.

There are not many Bwap traders or military personnel, but the race is peripherally associated with each field. Bwaps are often the best people to approach when trying to find a particular cargo, as they can often tell you down to the last detail who has what and how much. Terrans often use Bwaps as *de facto* brokers on Vilani worlds. Similarly, while they rarely engage directly in military operations, they are excellent in support roles, or as engineers aboard starships.

DISHAAN

Psychologically incapable of thinking past their own best interests, the Dishaan are in many ways the antithesis of the Vilani ideal. The Ziru Sirka has gone to heroic lengths to curb these impulses, but now that they are interacting with a non-Vilani state, the Dishaan are falling back into old habits.

History

Before the founding of the Ziru Sirka, several non-Vilani states flourished in parts of what is now Imperial space, and one of the most successful was *Ushkaq Sasutxi*, the Dishaan Hegemony.

Over the course of 1,000 years, the Dishaan built up a small empire of about 20 worlds based on Vilani technology. Moreover, they were great traders of the period, ranging far and wide across much of what is now the

Imperium, looking for riches to bring home. Their fundamental dishonesty was understood, so deals were always structured to make it worth their while to stick to the contract. Give a Dishaan half a chance, though, and he'd cheat you blind.

This propensity for chaos ran against the grain of Vilani goals in the period leading up to the Consolidation Wars, so the Dishaan were one of the first races to be attacked. It took 80 years of war to finally break the Dishaan, and then the Vilani were left with the problem of what to do with their new client race. It proved virtually impossible to impose Vilani culture on the Dishaan without piling on outrageously negative consequences for straying.

For the last 4,000 years, every Dishaan has been under constant surveillance, from birth to death. The Vilani strategy is to make certain that any deviation from acceptable norms is punished to an extent far greater than the potential gain of the crime. Most Dishaan are not allowed to leave their world unless they have considerable assets under Vilani control, which can be confiscated if their owner gets out of line. Those who do travel are usually merchants, though some work for the armed forces as solitary commandos with fearsome reputations among Terrans.

judge the distance to the next tree branch. Their "hands" are actually their feet – one more reason why they avoid standing on solid ground.

Psychology

The proto-Dishaan were pack animals, roaming in groups of 20 to 30 and driving predators away from their kills. Their social structure was based entirely around feeding rights, as maintained by continuous "pecking order" squabbles. Intelligence gradually developed as the Dishaan evolved ever more elaborate ways of subjugating their pack mates without resorting to physical violence.

The modern-day Dishaan is still constantly looking for angles, and has absolutely no compunction about doing anything that puts him one step ahead of someone else. He is honest exactly as long as it's to his advantage. The second he decides that cheating is better, that becomes his strategy.

Dishaan in the Interstellar Wars

Within the Imperium itself, the Dishaan are not as untrustworthy as they could be. On their home worlds they are constantly watched (by other Dishaan, in fact, as "traitors" are amply compensated). Since the Vilani harshly

I hate the Dishaan. Wrinkly, vulturous, black-hearted, love to scare you half to death. I get enough of that from my unit.

– Staff Sergeant John Sevdalian

Physiology

The Dishaan are five-foot-tall tree-dwellers with stubby legs that make them ungainly on the ground and long, powerful arms that make them masters in a forest canopy. Each arm is tipped with a large curved claw; these are intended to make grabbing the next branch easier, but they are also extremely effective in hand-to-hand combat. The claws are also used to take apart the carrion on which the Dishaan feed. Two widely set eyes on a broad, neckless head help them

punish lawbreaking, the calculation to break the rules rarely works out.

In Terran space, however, anyone dealing with a Dishaan needs to watch carefully – offworld they wear portable surveillance devices, but these don't work very well outside of a Vilani infrastructure. On the other hand, this also means that once out from the ever-watching eyes of the Vilani they're willing to cheat their masters in return for Terran goods; the race has been a valuable conduit for transferring Imperial technology into Terran hands.

A few Dishaan take “cheating” to its ultimate level, and love murder and looting for their own sake. In most eras there has been no outlet for this impulse, but recently the Vilani have returned to a tactic they used in the Consolidation Wars after the Dishaan were conquered. Solitary Dishaan – even a unit as large as a platoon is hard to hold together in wartime – are introduced into the field of operations and told to run wild. In forests or cities with high buildings they can make their way around far above the heads of Terrans, wreaking havoc behind the lines. These “Wreckers” are detested by Terran troops, and few survive capture. Equally few are around to be captured in the first place, however, as the Wrecker mindset is fortunately rare even among the Dishaan.

GEONEE

The Geonee are a variant of the Human species, one encountered by the Vilani not long after they went to the stars. What was most shocking about the encounter was that the Geonee had the jump drive as well, though it eventually came out that they had reverse-engineered it from a derelict ship they discovered in their home star system.

History

The Geonee were the greatest rival of the Vilani for over 3,500 years. They were the toughest opponent during the Consolidation Wars, but they were finally defeated (about the 4th century B.C.) and have been under Vilani rule ever since. Despite the millennia of subjugation, they still live on dozens of worlds somewhere to coreward of Terra, and are sometimes encountered by travelers headed in that direction.

Physiology

Geonee are smaller than most Humans, having adapted to a hot, high-gravity world; they average about 5 feet tall and 160 pounds, both male and female. Despite their small size, they are very strong and dense, with very little fat on their bodies.

The only other notable difference between the Geonee and Terrans is in their diet. Geonee are borderline carnivores, preferring to eat meat at



all times. While they can digest vegetable matter, and even use it as flavoring in some dishes, they have a hard time with more than a small amount of it in the diet.

Psychology

The Geonee possess much the same basic psychology as other Humans. Most of their psychological differences are imposed on them by their society.

Culturally, the Geonee are sexually dimorphic. Males are active and aggressive, while women are expected to be shy and retiring. In earlier times, women were actually considered chattels of their male relatives, but the Vilani ended this practice when they imposed their culture on the Geonee. Even so, to this day Geonee women are rarely encountered off a Geonee-dominated world.

Geonee men and women can only interact as relatives or, if courting, though the agency of a semi-intelligent creature called a *cerosee* that is native to the Geonee homeworld. The Geonee generally do not discuss this subject, and the *cerosee* are so shy and cautious that it is still not entirely certain that they actually exist. Some who study the Geonee believe that they may be metaphorical, a variety of “Cupid” in the Geonee courtship ritual.

The Geonee are extremely proud of their past, not only the relatively recent past when they were a space-faring power, but also a hypothetical Golden Age hundreds of thousands of years ago. During this Golden Age, the Geonee believe they had an even more advanced and widespread empire than that of the Imperium. They can be quite prickly about the subject, despite the fact that there is some evidence to suggest that they are wrong in this belief.

Anachronisms

Long-time players of *Traveller* probably recognize the Nugiiri as the Droyne, an enigmatic race scattered throughout Imperial space and beyond. They will know a great deal more about the Nugiiri than anyone living during the Interstellar Wars era. By the time of the Third Imperium, much of the mystery about the Nugiiri has been dispersed; GMs need to make sure that things their players might know don't leak out to the advantage of their characters. These are:

- **The Nugiiri are not native to Kilennur:** This is the one fact that Terrans have a chance to find out for themselves. If anyone with knowledge of the biological sciences can examine both the Nugiiri and Kilennur's biosphere, it will be obvious that the Nugiiri are from elsewhere.

- **The Nugiiri are part of a widely-dispersed race:** Even if they are discovered to be non-native to their "homeworld," it's still not obvious that the Nugiiri got there by colonizing the planet on their own initiative. Based on what the Terrans know, it's much likelier that the Nugiiri got their knowledge of interstellar travel from the Vilani at some forgotten point in the past. It would take a major archaeological expedition to discover evidence to the contrary (specifically, that the Nugiiri have been living on Kilennur for much longer than the Vilani have been in space).

Even the Vilani are unaware of this, despite there being multiple worlds with native Droyne colonies in the Imperium. Since the Vilani invented jump drive, the Droyne have been so secretive and unconnected with the universe as a whole that no one has realized that it's the same race on all of their worlds. In each case, they have been written off as simply another minor race, one native to the world where they were found.

In many cases, Droyne colonies are barely at the industrial level of technology. In the case of those (like Kilennur) that are more advanced, thousands of years of complete disinterest by the Droyne in the affairs of the Vilani have allayed all concerns. In the Interstellar

Wars period, it's unlikely that an Imperial official will even realize that an encountered Droyne is a member of this long-neglected species; he will likely dismiss it as belonging to some minor race he's never seen before.

- **The Nugiiri are psionic:** In the Interstellar Wars period, Terrans do not know that psionic powers exist, while the Vilani have only a very limited understanding of the phenomenon. If Terrans were to make a breakthrough on this front, it would likely be from study of the Nugiiri from Kilennur. However, there is a paradox here – there's no particular reason to study the Nugiiri in the first place until it's understood that they have fantastic powers of the mind.

- **The Nugiiri are an offshoot of the Ancients:** During the 22nd and 23rd centuries, it's not even clear that there ever was an Ancient civilization, much less that the Ancients were derived from a single race, or that that race is the Droyne. While the Nugiiri of Kilennur have a high-technology society, they are somewhat behind the Vilani. Their artifacts are radically different from Vilani ones, but this can easily be explained away as the effect of alien thought processes working on technology received from the Imperium.

- **The Nugiiri and the Chirpers are related:** Between the Ancient period 300,000 years ago and 70,000 years ago, the Droyne began losing their ability to caste. As this is a critical step to their development of full intelligence and adulthood, the colonies that lost this ability completely became "Chirpers," semi-intelligent creatures apparently no more related to Droyne than chimpanzees are to Humans. Some colonies developed "coyns" – coin-like focuses for the psionic casting ritual – and recovered, but many did not. In the Imperium, only the Geonee (p. 84) are in a position to make the connection between the two, but as Chirpers are involved in the courtship rituals of this repressed race, and they have their own name for the Chirpers, the topic is never discussed.

Geonee in the Interstellar Wars

The race is particularly interesting to Terrans for two reasons. One is that there is some contradictory evidence that they are the Ancients, or at least descendants of the Ancients (p. 13). More practically, they are interesting because they are the Vilani's most restive subject race. Even before Terra appeared on the scene, they had more than once revolted unsuccessfully against the *Ziru Sirka*. Given an opportunity to ally with the Confederation, there is reason to believe that they will take the chance.

NUGIIRI

One of the most unusual races known to the Terrans are the Nugiiri. Winged bipeds with an odd mixture of lizard-like and insect-like characteristics, they mostly keep to themselves and have been difficult to investigate.

History

What is known of the Nugiiri past is largely conjectural, but Terran xenologists have managed to construct the following theory.

The Nugiiri appear to be native to Kilennur, a world to spinward and

trailing of the Urima subsector, about a year's travel from Terra. Their native technology varies from Vilani norms like that of no other known race; what this implies about their origins and psychology is not yet clear. They were already relatively advanced before the Vilani conquered them, and they eventually allowed themselves to be absorbed by the *Ziru Sirka* in return for a promise to be left in isolation on Kilennur's southern continent. They have kept their part of the bargain in the centuries since, and are only rarely seen off their home world.

Physiology

The Nugiiri are hexapods, with a pair each of arms, legs, and wings. Their home world has lower gravity and a higher atmospheric density than Terra, and they can fly under such circumstances. In more Terra-like conditions, they are restricted to short-distance gliding.

The average member of the species is 50% smaller than a Human, and possesses a “hunched” quality that makes them look even smaller. Their basic external appearance is scaled and leathery, with a toothless, oval-shaped head. Their eyes are multifaceted like those of Terran insects.

The term “average member” is a bit misleading, however, as the Nugiiri possess several biologically derived castes, again similar to those of Terran insects like bees or termites. The smallest of these is barely 3' in height, while the largest averages 6'6". The exact nature of the castes is poorly understood, and it is not even known how many there are, but they seem to determine the individual's role in society. A few “pre-caste” Nugiiri have been encountered, so it is known that the caste is imposed at some point prior to adulthood, but how this occurs is also unknown.

Psychology

Each individual is shaped by its caste, and in most cases this severely limits its intellectual capabilities. Within the limits of the individual's function in society, it is quite adept, but without a community to embed itself within, it is quite helpless.

Two castes are exempt from this rule. The “leader” caste is rarely encountered away from Kilennur, but possesses Human-level intelligence and flexibility. The so-called “sport” caste is even more unusual, and even more independent. Sports appear to be the Nugiiri designed to handle the unforeseen, dealing with situations that are too quick or too distant for the leader caste to handle. As this includes trading and the rare Nugiiri diplomatic mission, sports are encountered by Humans more often than any other caste. “More often” is a relative term, though, and the Nugiiri would probably never be encountered by Terrans if their home world wasn't relatively close to Terra.

Nugiiri in the Interstellar Wars

By and large the Nugiiri keep to themselves, and actively discourage contact with outsiders. Even sports encountered away from home will avoid speaking with others, and be close-mouthed about their missions when avoidance is impossible.

SUERRAT

The third of the three great Human races that inhabited the area of the Imperium prior to the Consolidation Wars, the Suerrat are now grudging subjects of the Vilani. They differ from the Human physical norm more than most, and so still retain a strong identity despite Imperial efforts to bring them to heel.

History

The ancestral Suerrat lived in their homeworld's lush equatorial forests, and were well adapted to that environment. Early Suerrat literally lived in trees, having tamed, and then moved in with, a local predator that made burrows in the largest trunks. Over time they passed through the stages of civilization recognizable to any Terran historian.

The Suerrat paralleled the Vilani in technological development, with one major exception. The two races reached space within a few hundred years of each other, but the Vilani were the only ones to go on and develop the jump drive. The Suerrat used sublight gravitic drives instead. By the time they first encountered the Vilani, they had founded a state of about two dozen worlds, knit together by vast generation ships. The two civilizations traded, and soon the Suerrat had a considerable empire comparable to that of their brethren.

Like the Geonee, Dishaan, and others, the Suerrat were conquered during the Consolidation Wars. Like some of the others, they retain strong memories of their golden age of independence. Though not as actively rebellious as the Geonee, the Suerrat are likely to take up arms against the Imperium if an opportunity presents itself.

Physiology

The Suerrat are Human, though the casual observer might be forgiven for thinking otherwise. They exhibit several genetic traits that are dormant in Terrans or Vilani, producing what many Terrans think of as “ape-like” features. They are small, averaging just over 5' for males and just under that for females. Both weigh in at 130 pounds, which is quite heavy for their size. This is because they are very broad across the chest, and quite muscular – despite the size difference, the Suerrat are about as strong as Terran Humans.

More unusually, their feet are slightly prehensile. Suerrat shoes are usually more like mittens to Terran eyes, soft and freeing the big toe/thumb from the other toes to allow its use. On the right surfaces they are likely to go barefoot.

The most remarkable superficial difference is the coat of fur the Suerrat grow over most of their bodies, missing only on their palms, soles, and from the neck up. This fur is usually red and quite long, though it's worth noting that the Suerrat don't actually have more hair than Terrans – it's just that Terran “fur” is much finer and shorter than theirs. Curiously, Suerrat cannot grow facial hair.

The race has one other adaptation of note, though it is much more subtle than the others mentioned. Their home world orbits a dim red dwarf, and so their days are much less brightly illuminated than those of Terra or Vland. As a result, their retinas are more sensitive than those of Terrans, their eyes are slightly larger, and their pupils are larger still. Some Terrans find their gaze annoying for reasons they can't place; this is probably because their eyes are subtly different from what we're used to.

Practically, this means that the Suerrat are comfortable with a much lower light level than a Terran or Vilani would be. A Suerrat room might be lit by no more than one or two bright LEDs, dim but acceptable to them, uncomfortable and dangerous to a Terran. On the other hand, Suerrat find it difficult to see in the full light of G-class or F-class stars, and have to wear sunglasses on planets orbiting them.



Psychology

The Suerrat have lived in the trees for their entire history, even in the modern period when every group of buildings is associated with a large central tree. Suerrat are more interested in nature than most Human races, but they balance this with a love of crowds and sociability. Their cities are odd mixtures of vast, empty areas needed to support the trees and their associated ecology, punctuated by densely populated “downtowns” where they can meet and interact.

Suerrat sociability extends naturally to other species; a Suerrat’s first reaction on encountering a creature that isn’t obviously violent is to attempt to communicate. They are very good at taming animals, and their cities are often home to an astonishing variety of domesticated creatures. While Suerrat and Terrans have not

had much direct contact, there is already a growing trade in all varieties of Terran animal (and not just ones usually intended to be pets).

Suerrat in the Interstellar Wars

Outside the worlds of their former empire, the Suerrat occupy a special niche in the Imperium. Having colonized space first with sublight drives, they were in no position to be picky about the worlds they settled, and most of them were heavily flawed. Over time, they became masters of living in extreme environments.

When the Suerrat were conquered by the Vilani, their environmental technology wasn’t absorbed so much as it was co-opted; to this day they are the ones best suited to run it. Vilani usually live on Vland-like worlds, but even with jump-2 drives many airless

or otherwise uninhabitable planets are needed as outposts. The Suerrat make up a significant minority of the population on these worlds, helping to run the systems, and are doubly suited to work in outposts in low or zero-G environments thanks to their prehensile feet.

This puts the Suerrat in the unusual position of being able to maintain some of their own lifestyle despite the Imperial tendency for cultural assimilation. As the life-support technicians in Imperial space, Suerrat have managed to intermix their ecological views with Vilani technology; their outposts are considerably more pleasant than similar installations in Terran space. The adaptation of Suerrat technology in this field, and of Suerrat to run it, has been a lucrative source of technology transfer since not long after Terra invented its own jump drive.

VEGANS

The first truly alien race encountered by Terrans, the Vegans occupy several worlds near the star Vega, just outside the current coreward border of the Confederation.



History

Like most other subject races, the Vegans received the jump drive from others. Vilani influence was still far away when this happened, but traders from the powerful Geonee state to coreward passed the secret on about 1500 B.C. A conservative race, the Vegans built up a small state about 10 parsecs in diameter around their home world Muan Gwi, then settled down to assimilate what they had taken.

Unfortunately for them, the Vegans were the last known spacefaring race as one headed to the Rim – in other words, they were the obvious anchor on one border of the *Ziru Sirka* when the Imperium was first proposed. For a while they were protected by having the Geonee between them and the Vilani, but after that race was conquered the days of Vegan independence were numbered. The Vilani conquered the original Vegan Polity by about 120 A.D.

Since then the Vegans have been carefully trying to find a way out of their predicament. While not aggressive, or even particularly resentful of the Imperium, they would rather be their own masters. With lives spanning several centuries from birth to death,

the Vegans are cautious by Human standards, and have never brought a plan all the way to the point of rebellion. With the right spark from Terra, though, this may change.

Physiology

Vegans are roughly humanoid, but they diverge strongly from Human appearance. Muan Gwi is a small world, so they are very tall – often over 7' in height – but frail and unable to handle Terran gravity for any length of time. Their eyes are at the top of their body at the end of a long fleshy hood; strictly speaking this isn't a "head," in that it doesn't contain any other sensory organs nor can it turn independently of the rest of the body. Vegans hear through a series of ear holes around their shoulders, and a mouth pierces the chest. The mouth isn't dual purpose like a Human's, being only for eating their vegetarian diet; breathing slits flank it on either side.

Muan Gwi is quite arid, so Vegan legs bear a superficial resemblance to those of Terran camels, especially in their broad, soft feet that can easily handle sandy ground. Vegan arms split into many tentacles just below the elbow, producing an odd "hand" that makes it difficult for a Vegan to use Human equipment and vice versa.

Psychology

Terrans often characterize Vegans as stoic, but this is not true. Vegans

actually have a range of emotions quite similar to ours, surprisingly for such an alien race. The difference is that their emotions are much *weaker* than those of Humans, to the point that they are rarely swept away by what they feel.

As a result, Vegans are much less ambitious and driven than Humans, and will think about things rather than act. In the Imperium this is probably a good thing, as the thoroughness with which the Vilani put down rebellion would bring disaster if the Vegans ever acted on their feelings about being subjected.

Vegan society before the Consolidation Wars was somewhat similar to that of the Vilani, with citizens divided into castes named *tuhuir*. Despite the similarity, the Vegans find it troubling to live by Vilani ways, as they miss subtleties of the *tuhuir* system that matched particular Vegan needs. There is also resentment at the Imperium's controls on innovation in art, philosophy, and mathematics; these three topics are of great interest to the thoughtful Vegans.

Vegans in the Interstellar Wars

Though other subject races are more obviously opposed to being part of the Imperium, the Vegans may have made the most progress through sheer passive resistance. They follow Vilani dictates in letter, not spirit, and only to the minimum extent necessary to keep the Imperium from cracking down. They follow orders, and back down when challenged, but constantly test the limits of what they can do. After 2,000 years of practice, they are masters of being infuriating without seeming the least bit threatening.

From a Terran standpoint, there are very few races that would make better neighbors. Vegans will follow their own interests without qualms as long as they think they can get away with it. They will gladly help Terrans whenever the help brings discomfort to the Vilani and doesn't endanger Vegan society. As a result, they have proven to be very useful trading partners and sources of intelligence. In many ways they are the Confederation's window onto the rest of the Imperium.

THE VILANI MILITARY

The doctrine of “hit it with a big hammer” is indeed crude, but the Vilani have a very large hammer, and have been pounding nails for a very long time. Of course, it has been almost as long since any of the nails have really fought back.

– *Hauptmann Heinrich Guthard,*
Terran Confederation Marines (2166)

THE VILANI WAY OF WAR

It's been many generations since the Vilani have faced a threat that couldn't be easily crushed by the combined forces of the Navy and Army. The greatest danger to the Vilani is complacency; being on top for so long makes it difficult to imagine another force capable of giving a good fight.

In the millennia that the *Ziru Sirka* has ruled the stars, the Vilani have developed an efficient military machine that is dependent on two things: strict adherence to procedures, and overwhelming force.

To the Vilani military, “The Book” is everything. The Vilani have compiled a vast collection of doctrine and tactics, some of it stretching back to before the Consolidation Wars. The natural conservatism of the Vilani mindset makes it difficult for commanders in the field to improvise, and their training doesn't even bother with realistic exercises to teach them this critical skill. A good way to look at this side of the Vilani military is to think of officers as skilled technicians, able to function within the limits of their training, but forced to refer to “The Book” when anything goes wrong. There are exceptions to this rule – officers who can improvise effectively – but these are rare.

Along with The Book, the *Ziru Sirka* meets threats with overwhelming force. This is an expression of the Vilani desire for short, “cost-efficient” wars. Even in pre-industrial times on Vland, actual combat was considered wasteful of lives and resources. It was considered far better form to muster a massive force and convince the opponent that

resistance would be disaster for him. To this day, the Vilani are likely to open any campaign with a careful attempt at intimidation.

On the other hand, the bluff needs to be carried through if called. If a weaker force chooses to fight, it must be smashed, and collateral damage is not an issue – it's even a benefit. Wanton destruction produces terror and economic hardship, hopefully delivering a lesson that will last long into the peace that follows any war.

If an enemy manages to put up a good fight, the Vilani are likely to stand down and wait for another opportunity. Even during the Consolidation Wars, the Vilani were capable of great patience; they could wait for decades to deliver final defeat to an opponent. Today's more complacent Imperium is even more likely to back down if Terran or allied forces are able to resist the first assault, giving the Confederation a chance to rebuild and regroup.

The Vilani and Glory

The Vilani concept of military glory differs considerably from the Terran version.

The Vilani rarely award medals to *individuals* for achievement on the field of battle. Instead, entire units are recognized, even if only one or two soldiers performed heroically. Perhaps it was Private Kikiima who took out the enemy gun crew after charging 100 yards under heavy fire – but his fellow soldiers gave him covering fire, and his leaders trained him to be able to perform the feat. Hence it's the platoon as a whole that gets the “attaboy” from a commander.

The Vilani don't give medals as we think of them. Instead, the unit receives thanks or a gift from a senior commander. The further the praise originates from up the chain of command, the higher its value. Units hold these gifts and notes in high regard, and display them proudly. A gift might be as simple as a vial of soil from the battle site or a piece of debris from an enemy ship, or a family heirloom from the commander's clan. The rules governing the giving and display of these gifts are quite intricate.

While a Vilani trooper won't get medals pinned to his chest, he is still just as brave as his Terran counterparts. The base motivation for bravery (“please, don't let me be a coward and let my buddies down”) is the same in both Terran and Vilani units. Vilani are already attuned to the opinions of others in their civilian society; they remain so in the military.

Of course, the Vilani expect any “barbarian” enemy to use the same tactics of terror and destruction against *them*, if given the chance. This is one reason why the Imperium tries to apply overwhelming force; the plan is to keep any enemy far too busy defending himself to play havoc with Imperial civilian populations. If an enemy *does* manage to break into the Imperial rear, the threat can unhinge an otherwise well-planned offensive as undefended worlds shout for help.

THE VILANI NAVY

The *Aasha Ziru Sirka* (“Fleet of the Grand Empire of Stars”) has been the unquestioned master of the galaxy for thousands of years. Naval personnel *know* they cannot be beaten, and any small losses against barbarians, rebellious provinces, or other renegades are written off as bad luck.

Overall Organization

The *Aasha* doesn't have permanent fleets in the sense that Terrans think of them. Instead, the Vilani assemble fleets as needed from available units, and place senior officers in charge of them for the duration. That being said, there are some squadrons (*mashushshi*) composed of so many ships as to be fleets by Terran standards.

While this lack of consistent organization seems odd to most, it serves the Vilani well. Naval assets are found throughout the territory of a *shangarim*, and these ships can be quickly assembled into the sledgehammer so beloved in Imperial doctrine. Also, the lack of permanent fleets limits the power of commanders in the field, making it harder for one malcontent to gather enough power to be a threat.

In times of war, regional governors order their squadrons into service, and appoint senior officers to command the fleets. Occasionally a governor or other *shangarim* executive of high rank will take personal command of a task force, but this is not common practice. In many cases, commanding officers are recommended by their fellows. The non-linear nature of Vilani ranks makes it easy for a good starship captain to become the equivalent of a Fleet Admiral for the duration of a crisis, then go back to being a simple captain at the end of hostilities.

Vilani naval forces are usually organized around groups of 10: 10 ships make up a squadron, 10 squadrons make up a fleet, and so on. Groups of 10 are often broken into paired groups of five in order to cover more space during extended operations. This isn't a rule or formal regulation, but a simple habit that has become part of Vilani thinking. It is prevalent enough that Terran commanders have developed a rule of thumb: "If you see five Vilani ships, assume there are five more nearby."

Of course, the Vilani aren't unconscious of their "counting by 10s" foible. Vilani slang includes a set of metaphorical expressions that has spread beyond the Imperial Navy into Vilani society as a whole. For example, a formation or organization that's been badly damaged is said to be "counting by eights."

A leader who does the job with insufficient resources is said approvingly to be "counting by nines," whereas the same phrase is used *disapprovingly* of a leader who acts before he is ready. The Vilani say that the Terrans always count by nines, and when a Vilani refers to a "Terran 10," he means *nine*!

A leader who makes sure that every detail is taken care of, and who builds up overwhelming force before acting, is said to be "counting by 11s." This is usually a compliment.

On the other hand, a commander or leader who rarely acts, because he's too busy complaining that he doesn't have enough assets to complete the job, is said to be "counting by 12s." This is *not* a compliment.

One of the battleships will be equipped with a specialized command-and-control center, along with stealth and heavy ECM systems, and will serve as the battlegroup's flagship.

The majority of the battlegroups are held in the Imperium's interior regions. Given the political situation at the time of the early Interstellar Wars, the *shangarim* felt a strong need to keep their strongest weapons close to the centers of power. These fleets were sent to regional governors only in times of dire need, and even then only at great political cost to the governor who called for them.

Cruisers

Displacing 4,000 to 20,000 dtons, the cruisers of the *Aasha* are the heavy ships most often seen on the frontiers. These vessels are equipped for long

Naval Rank

Rank in the *Aasha* is complex. Unlike navies built on the American or European model, there is no linear hierarchy of ranks. Instead, everything is based on function and position.

To this end, the names of ranks take full advantage of the tonal nature of the Vilani language. For example, *Merishmirra*⁶ means cruiser (*merishmir*) captain. *Merishmirra*⁵ means a senior staff officer on board a cruiser, usually an executive or department head. If a *Merishmirra*⁶ officer was to be transferred to a staff position on a large base, his rank would become *Gamirirem*, with the final syllable toned to indicate seniority. This system is very confusing to Terrans, as the tonal changes are subtle, and the concept of changing rank names entirely with each transfer is unfamiliar.

Because of all the different names, there are more than 50 distinct ranks in the *Aasha*, and even more if one considers tonal variations. Trying to remember that *Kurmaruushririi*³ means "second assistant jump technician" while the same word toned differently means "senior fleet engineer" gives most Terran intelligence officers headaches.

Battlegroups

The heart of the *Aasha* *Ziru Sirka*, the Vilani battlegroups (*gaashnarru*) are the force used to enforce the will of central command. The typical Vilani dreadnought or battleship displaces at least 20,000 dtons, and uses massive missile batteries for its main punch. These ships are organized into squadrons of 10, plus escorts and support vessels. The escort fleet is small, usually one or two cruisers per battleship, along with a handful of smaller vessels of 500-dton to 5,000-dton size.

patrols (at jump-2, any significant patrolling takes many months) and are quite comfortable. Like battleships, they are noteworthy for their large missile magazines. Commanders of *Aasha* cruisers are the most independent-minded in the fleet, since they spend a great amount of time away from more senior commanders. On the other hand, they still have "The Book" hanging around their necks, and a duty to report on all actions while out in the field. Few take advantage of their isolation.

Smaller cruisers operate in “wolf packs” of 10 ships. They patrol together and attack targets of opportunity. Terran commanders quickly learn to be wary of such tactics. The larger ships are used as a reaction force, held at a fleet headquarters until word of an attack comes in. They are also deployed as heavy, short-legged patrollers, securing a small number of worlds (usually along a main).

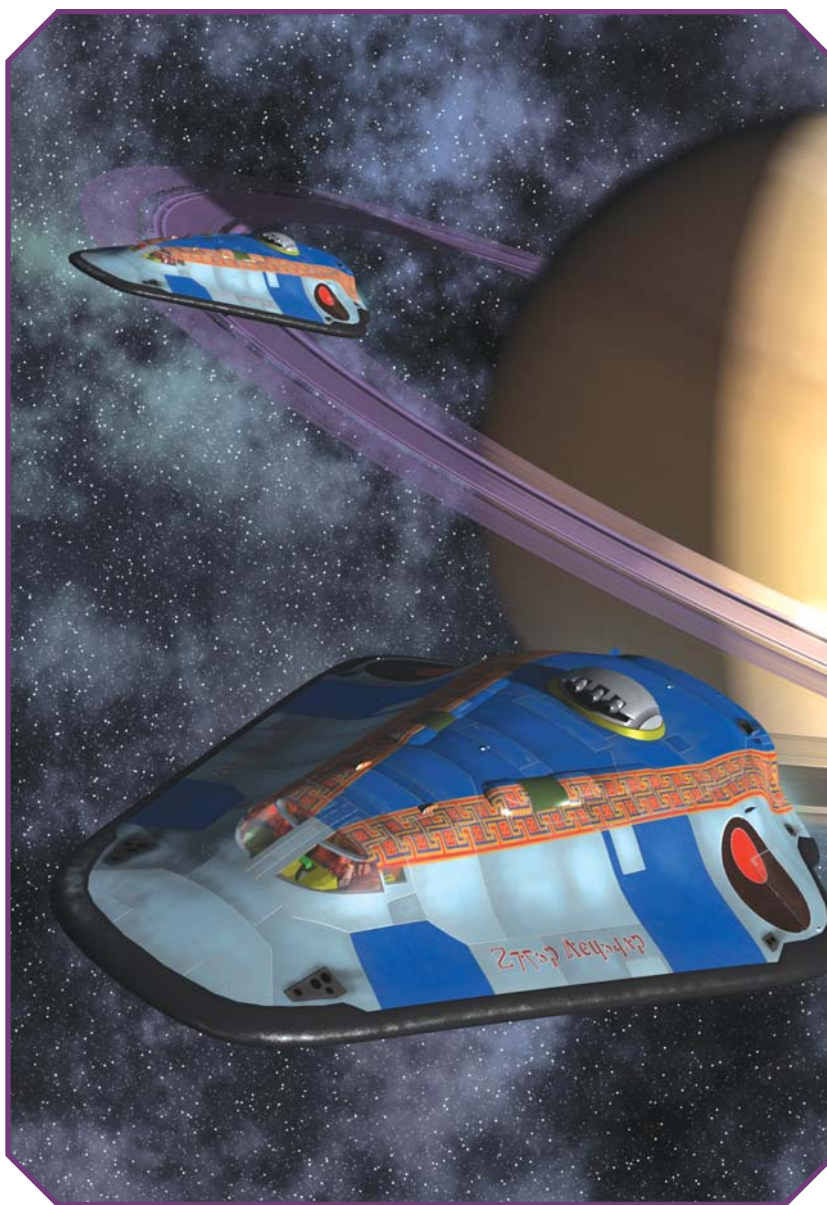
Destroyers and Escorts

The Vilani place little faith in smaller vessels. They don’t fit into the “big hammer” strategy, and few of the Vilani’s opponents can muster a credible space threat, making the need for a small escort minimal. The few smaller ships the Vilani do use are for escorting civilian vessels and conducting what is best described as customs duties: boarding ships and searching for contraband.

There are larger escorts, displacing 1,000 to 4,000 dtons, which accompany capital ships and cruisers to protect them from missiles and fighters. These ships and their crews carry little prestige, and are held in contempt by those serving on other ships.

Fighters

The Vilani rely heavily on their fighters, short-range ships displacing from 10 to 50 dtons that are used for everything from in-system patrols to massed assaults on battleships. Vilani fighters (*dhue*) usually carry one or two missile racks, with a few point-defense models carrying a laser weapon. In smaller fighters, weapons are in fixed mounts. The largest fighters carry turrets and crews of two or three men. There are also specialized



fighters for EW, ground attack, and recon.

To transport the wings of fighters, the *Aasha* uses massive carriers. More like mobile bases than warships, the

carriers displace up to 40,000 dtons. Each holds hundreds of fighters, organized into 10-ship squadrons. Fighter squadrons do not necessarily use a single type of fighter; in fact, *dhue* squadrons are organized around their pilots, not the vessels they fly.

The Vilani Marines?

There is no organization in the Vilani military comparable to the Terran Marine Corps. The line between Army and Navy is strictly drawn, and neither service can conceive of a force under the control of one that would execute some of the duties of the other. The closest thing the Imperium has to an elite Marine force is the *Shigniit Dia Ugkin*, the “Legion of the Frontier” (see p. 94).

The *Aasha* does have security troops for shipboard actions and guarding naval institutions, but these are considered naval personnel. Meanwhile, the Army has a few interface craft.

Support Ships

The *Aasha Ziru Sirka* uses hundreds of different classes of support ships. Given the nature of the Imperial government, many of them are simply “civilian” vessels given a new set of orders. Most common are freighters that have been converted to serve as troop carriers or other combat support ships.



Naval Bases

The Vilani rarely settle unpleasant worlds unless they are important to transportation routes. Logically, then, the Vilani should put their naval bases in the same locations, as by definition their outposts are at chokepoints for fleet movements.

This theory, however, depends on the false assumption that the Vilani worry about stopping fleet movements. It has been almost 2,000 years since anyone fielded a large group of ships against them, and in that time the bases have shifted to protecting individual worlds of importance. Naval bases are therefore almost always placed on Garden worlds, which also solves the problem of leave for stationed personnel.

Naval Strategy

The Vilani expect to know about trouble before it brews, but placing the bases at important planets is intended to guard against times when they do not. In the first stages of a war, the fleets defend their bases and associated worlds. Individual units are detached if the opposition is sufficiently weak, or if a target of opportunity presents itself, but in general system defense is the squadron's first purpose.

While deployed units carry out system defense, other units gather at a convenient *eshiimar* ("marshaling yard") for orders. On average, there is one depot per 10 naval bases, and they are in mothballs for long periods of time, activated only when hostilities begin. The Vilani *eshiimar* closest to Terra is at Dingir; with the constant threat of warfare on the rimward frontier, the Vilani have taken the unusual step of keeping it open continually (though ships still only gather there when the shooting starts).

Once a sufficiently large number of units has gathered, they set out from the marshaling point to demonstrate that one does not challenge the Imperium. The usual tactic is to pick a main that runs from the depot to the source of the trouble, mopping up any resistance along the way with overwhelming shows of force. If this is enough to end the fighting, so much the better, but the *Aasha* is perfectly willing to blast opposing vessels into marble-sized pieces.

Army Rank

Compared to the Navy, the *Gisadia* uses a simple rank structure. There are only six enlisted ranks and eight officer grades. There are also the *amrimkhar*, the equivalent of warrant officers without command duties, who hold technical jobs that require status. See Chapter 6 for a summary of Imperial Army ranks.

Convoy Escort

The Terran Confederation has offered the first notable threat to Vilani lines of trade in over 1,000 years, so the Imperium is relearning how to protect its shipping. Unfortunately for them, the parts of “The Book” devoted to the topic assume that the enemy is limited to jump-1 ships, which is not the case for most of the Interstellar Wars. For the first time since the Consolidation Wars, The Book needs a new chapter. To date, the Vilani have been abysmal at coming up with tactics to deal with the situation; this is fortunate, as once the *Aasha* gets rolling there’s not a lot for Terran units to do besides commerce raiding.

THE VILANI ARMY

The *Ziru Sirka* has successfully held onto an empire of thousands of worlds, for thousands of years. Much of the credit can be given to the *Gisadia Ziru Sirka* – the “Army of the Grand Empire of Stars.”

Over the centuries the army has gone from being little more than a mob to a highly professional force, then back again. These changes have always been dependent on the current state of security in the Empire. During times of relative peace, the Army has usually failed to maintain its funding against encroachments from the Navy or the *shangarim*. When war looms, or when (as has been the case recently) rebellions have flared, the Army gains stature.

Currently the Army is on the upswing, although in many regions the level of training remains little better than that of a heavily armed police force. Conservatism and the lack of a real foe has left many units composed of “parade ground troops” – troops who look good during drill, but perform poorly in combat.

General Doctrine

The *Gisadia* relies on large, heavy formations to establish superiority quickly, then tries to defeat the enemy in detail. This requires space superiority, which the *Ziru Sirka* has enjoyed for its entire history.

The Vilani don’t make frequent use of “drop troops,” forces trained to make re-entry in individual capsules, as a regular part of their force structure. A few special operations units do use this tactic on occasion, but it is rare. Instead, orbital bombardment is applied to suppress local defenses, then landing craft are used to shuttle whole battalions down at one time.

Ever wonder what goes on inside a Vilani officer's head? No? Neither does he.

– Common Terran Army joke (c. 3012)

The reason the Vilani do not make use of this tactic isn’t technological, but psychological. In any sort of drop, be it from a low-flying aircraft or a ship in orbit, the forces being dropped will experience disruption of command lines due to troops being scattered. Terran troops deal with this by training such forces to act with individual initiative until command is reestablished. To the Vilani, it is inconceivable that a soldier could land and fight alone without direction.

Unlike the regulars, the *Shigniud Dia Ugkin* (p. 94) does make effective use of drop troops.

Infantry Battalions

The base formation of the *Gisadia* is the *nadshemi*, or “infantry battalion.” The 1,200 or so troops in one

nadshemi do the hard job of taking and holding ground. The Vilani infantry are vehicle-poor, with light-skinned APCs as their only means of transportation and support.

The battalion commander has a relatively large staff. Along with the “normal” staff positions such as operations, intelligence and supply, he has additional staff for public relations and security. He also has a number of officers holding the uniquely Vilani position *shugilii*, acting as a sort of chaplain’s corps.

Each battalion has six companies: five infantry and one for command and support.

Tank Battalions

The Army also deploys *ishkaaim*, or “tank battalions.” The Imperium still uses ground vehicles for its heavy tanks. The largest are wheeled or tracked, but the majority of them are ground effect vehicles. Vilani tanks use missiles and rapid-fire cannon to destroy the enemy. Imperial armor

tactics resemble classic cavalry tactics of the pre-industrial era – probe for weakness, then get into the rear area to raise havoc.

Because of the difficulty in transporting ground vehicles, armor units make up a very small percentage of the forces used on the offensive. More often than not, they are found in the defense, where they can prepare for enemy attacks. Tanks are also used to occupy particularly restive worlds; the Vilani are not above using armored formations to literally crush civilian uprisings when necessary.

Tank battalions consist of three oversized companies along with a command and support company. The battalion commander has a smaller staff than his infantry counterpart, and is dependent on higher command for intelligence and much of his support.

Larger Formations

Gisadia forces rarely move in groups smaller than division strength. Units of this size, called *lurkugi*, are made up of six combat battalions, extra artillery (mostly missiles), and a support battalion.

The next larger unit is the *kuearda*, a corps-strength group of three to five *lurkugi*. Extra forces are added as needed. A unit of this size is only moved when a grave threat is perceived.

Beyond the *kuearda* is the *sukau-uaashdug*, or “supreme army group,” a collection of forces that haven’t been used on the offensive in centuries. Each *sukauuaashdug* has several *kuearda* and whatever support its commander feels necessary. An Army officer commanding such a unit is one of the few who can confidently give orders to the Navy.

The Shigniïd Dia Ugkin

Occupying a unique niche in the Ziru Sirka military, the *Shigniïd Dia Ugkin* (“Legion of the Frontier”) is the wild card in the otherwise predictable Vilani armed forces. Made up of subject-race troopers, malcontents, and outright criminals, the *Shigniïd Dia Ugkin* is a cross between a penal battalion and the French Foreign Legion.

The *Shigniïd Dia Ugkin* is composed solely of assault troops. In training and temperament, the force is unsuited to almost any other role. It is thrown into battle with little regard for casualties, since its members are not what the Vilani consider ideal citizens in any case. The troops of the Legion have developed a fatalistic attitude that is best summed up by its unofficial

motto: “*Diduma inshaiirshurla aipgia ginagkhuuirkake kakiinkhish khiik-ishela ad.*” (“We have come here to die, and only the gods and officers know when that will happen.”) *Shigniïd Dia Ugkin* units operate their own spacecraft, and can be used as privateers in war.

supplies, and they tend to always be under-stocked. To counter this, the Legion has developed a tradition of looting and adaptation. *Shigniïd Dia Ugkin* units carry a wide variety of personal weapons, gear, and even uniforms.

The Frontier Legion’s motto starts, “We have come here to die . . .” I think ours should be “Always happy to oblige.”

– Staff Sergeant John Sevdalian (3025)

Recruiting for the *Shigniïd Dia Ugkin* is difficult. Unlike Terrans, who find units like the Foreign Legion romantic, the typical Vilani sees the Legion as the equivalent of a prison sentence. Indeed, many of the Legion’s recruits are accepted directly from prisons, or are given a choice between service and “hard time” when convicted of crimes. Others are encouraged to join by families who wish to hide a “black sheep.”

Legion officers are theoretically assigned from the regular Army, but here too the *Shigniïd Dia Ugkin* is seen as a convenient dumping ground for junior officers who fail to conform to the Vilani way. This results in the *Shigniïd Dia Ugkin* being, by far, the most versatile force in the Imperial Army. It is on par with a good Terran unit with regard to innovation and tactical flexibility.

One difficulty faced by the Legion is supply. *Shigniïd Dia Ugkin* storehouses are always the last to get

One unifying factor in the Legion is its love of bladed weapons. From the *kiikag* (a dagger with a brass knuckle-like guard) to the *khapsish* (a heavy, cutlass-like blade), no member of the *Shigniïd Dia Ugkin* feels comfortable without his blade. Those who have survived assaults by the *Shigniïd Dia Ugkin* describe howling mobs waving swords, even when boarding spacecraft!

Members of the *Shigniïd Dia Ugkin* know their reputation, and work to enhance it. They tend to decorate any vehicles they come to possess with images of skulls and fire, wear as much ammunition as possible (along with the knives, of course), and even go to extremes in personal grooming.

Although the *Shigniïd Dia Ugkin* can be found almost anywhere along the Imperial border, it is organized into units no larger than a company. There is usually one group of five Legion companies per frontier sector.

